

The window was built high up so that the children could not look out and be distracted from their work.

Teachers often carried a cane with them. If the children were bad they would be smacked.

This is an abacus, or counting frame. Children learned to add and subtract by moving the beads along the wires.

Each child in the class had only one reading book. It contained stories and poems, and had to last the whole year.

Young children learned to write on slates, which could be wiped clean and used again. Later they were allowed to use ink and paper.

The desks were very simple. The shelf underneath held the children's books.

Slate pencils were made of a piece of soft slate, or soapstone, wrapped in paper.

The desks had special holes made in them to hold the inkwells.



Stitch by stitch

Samplers were very popular in schools. They consisted of a piece of embroidery designed to show a girl's skill in using different stitches. Girls began to make them at an early age. They were a way of teaching them the alphabet and their sewing at the same time.

